

Missing-Subject Fragments

In each example below, underline the word group in which the subject is missing.

Example 1

The truck skidded on the rain-slick highway. But missed a telephone pole on the side of the road.

Example 2

Michelle tried each of the appetizers on the table. And then found that, when the dinner arrived, her appetite was gone.

People write missing-subject fragments because they think the subject in one sentence will apply to the next word group as well. But the subject, as well as the verb, must be in *each* word group to make it a sentence.

Correcting Missing-Subject Fragments

- 1 Attach the fragment to the preceding sentence. Example 1 could read: "The truck skidded on the rain-slick highway but missed a telephone pole on the side of the road."
- 2 Add a subject (which can often be a pronoun standing for the subject in the preceding sentence). Example 2 could read: "She then found that, when dinner arrived, her appetite was gone."

Activity

Underline the missing-subject fragment in each item. Then rewrite that part of the item needed to correct the fragment. Use one of the two methods of correction described above.

1. I tried on an old suit hanging in our basement closet. And discovered, to my surprise, that it was too tight to button.
 - 1) I tried ... closet and discovered, to my surprise, that it ... button.
 - 2) I tried ... closet, and I discovered, to ... to button

2. When Mary had a sore throat, friends told her to gargle with salt water. Or suck on an ice cube. The worst advice she got was to avoid swallowing.

1) When Mary had ... water or suck ... swallowing.

2) When Mary had ... water

3. One of my grade-school teachers embarrassed us with her sarcasm. Also, seated us in rows from the brightest student to the dumbest. I can imagine the pain the student in the last seat must have felt.

1) One of my ... sarcasm, also seated ... dumbest. I can ... felt.

2) One of my ... sarcasm. She also ... dumbest. I can ... felt.

A Review: How to Check for Fragments

- 1 Read your paper aloud from the *last* sentence to the *first*. You will be better able to see and hear whether each word group you read is a complete thought.
- 2 If you think a word group is a fragment, ask yourself: Does this contain a subject and a verb and express a complete thought?
- 3 More specifically, be on the lookout for the most common fragments:
 - Dependent-word fragments (starting with words like *after*, *because*, *since*, *when*, and *before*)
 - -ing and to fragments (-ing or to at or near the start of a word group)
 - Added-detail fragments (starting with words like *for example*, *such as*, *also*, and *especially*)
 - Missing-subject fragments (a verb is present but not the subject)

■ Review Test 1

Turn each of the following word groups into a complete sentence. Use the spaces provided.

Example With sweaty palms

With sweaty palms, I walked in for the job interview.

Even when it rains

The football teams practice even when it rains.